MEMBER GUIDES · C6A

Your year as a Steward

Usually the first office a Brother holds, and the one that teaches the Lodge who you are. A short guide to what it involves, what to learn, and who will help.

For	The Brother about to be invested as Steward, and his Personal Mentor
Issue	Issue 1 (Draft for Review), October 2026 · One of six Officer Guides, Steward to Senior Warden. The office is described here; the words and floorwork are learned at the Lodge of Instruction, never from a document.

1 What the office is

The Stewards look after the comfort of the Lodge and its guests, mostly at the Festive Board: seeing that visitors are welcomed and seated, that glasses are charged before the toasts, that the raffle and the charity collection happen, and that nobody is left without company. In the Lodge room you will have little or no ritual to deliver; your job is to watch, learn and be useful. Most Lodges have several Stewards, and most Masters started here.

Your jewel	A cornucopia, the horn of plenty, on a collar. You will be invested with it at the Installation.

2 What you will actually do

- Arrive early. The Director of Ceremonies and the Junior Warden will tell you what the evening needs; ask if they do not.

- Welcome visitors in the bar and at the table. Find out who is dining alone and sit someone with them, or sit there yourself.
- Help with the raffle, the alms collection and the wine, as your Lodge's custom dictates.
- Learn the shape of a meeting: the order of business, the Risings, who moves where and why. Sit where you can see the floorwork.
- Learn the Festive Board: the order of toasts, Hertfordshire fire, and when to stand.
- If you are a Steward at an Installation or an Official Visit, expect a busier night; the DC will brief you.

3 What to learn, and how

- There is usually nothing to learn by heart as a Steward, and that is the point: the year is for learning the Lodge.
- Start on next year's office now. Ask the Inner Guard to show you what he does, and borrow the words.
- Visit another Lodge and watch their Stewards. Lodges do these things differently, and you will pick up good ideas.

4 Things nobody tells you

- The Stewards' most useful job is the one on no list: noticing the Brother at the end of the table whom nobody is talking to.
- Reliable attendance as a Steward is the strongest signal a Lodge reads when it plans its office queue.
- You are allowed to enjoy it. The Stewards' table is often the liveliest in the room.

5 The time it takes

One meeting a month in the season, the Lodge of Instruction if you can, and a little time with the DC before an Installation. It should fit comfortably around home and work; if it does not, say so.

6 Who will help

Your Personal Mentor	Still yours. Office does not end mentoring; it changes the conversation. Tell him if the learning is not going well, or the diary.
The Director of Ceremonies	Owns the ceremonies and the floor. He will tell you what your Lodge does, which is what matters; Lodges differ.
The Preceptor and the Lol	Where the office is learned. Go even in the weeks when there is nothing for you to do.
The Lodge Mentor	Watches the office queue for the whole Lodge: nobody pushed before he is ready, nobody left waiting. Say so to him if either is happening to you.
The Province	mentor@hertfordshirefreemasons.org.uk, the monthly mentoring call on the first Tuesday at 7pm, and Solomon (solomon.ugle.org.uk), which has a paper on every office.

7 Looking ahead

Inner Guard, usually. Your Lodge Mentor and the DC will talk to you about it before the Master decides, and if you would rather have another year as a Steward, that is a good answer too.

> **For your mentor.** Three questions for the conversation before the Installation: Does he want this office this year, and has he said so to his family? What is the one piece he is worried about, and who will help him with it? What will we do together in the second half of the year to make the next office feel easy?
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> **Readiness, not pressure, in either direction.** Nobody should take an office before he feels able, and nobody capable should be left waiting. Family, Work, Masonry: in that order, always.

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